

Aeschylus  
THE EUMENIDES  
[THE KINDLY ONES]

Translated by  
Ian Johnston  
Vancouver Island University  
Nanaimo, BC  
Canada

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TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Note that in the following text the line numbers in square brackets refer to the Greek text, and the line numbers without brackets refer to the text of the translation.

In this translation, possessives of names ending in -s are usually indicated in the common way (that is, by adding -'s (e.g. *Zeus* and *Zeus's*). This convention adds a syllable to the spoken word (the sound -iz). Sometimes, for metrical reasons, this English text indicates such possession in an alternate manner, with a simple apostrophe. This form of the possessive does not add an extra syllable to the spoken name (e.g., *Orestes* and *Orestes'* are both three-syllable words).

The *Eumenides* is the third play in the series of three plays which make up the *Oresteia*.

EUMENIDES

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

PRIESTESS: prophetic priestess (the Pythia) of Apollo at Delphi.

APOLLO: divine son of Zeus, god of prophecy.

ORESTES: son of Agamemnon and Clytaemnestra, brother of Electra.

CLYTAEMNESTRA: mother of Orestes, appearing as a ghost after her murder.

CHORUS: Furies, goddesses of blood revenge.

ATHENA: divine daughter of Zeus.

ATHENIAN CITIZENS.

*[Scene: The play opens just in front of the temple of Apollo at Delphi. Enter the Pythia, the Priestess of Apollo.]*

PRIESTESS

In my prayer, I hold Earth in highest honour,  
as the first of prophets among all gods.  
Then, after her came Themis. That goddess,  
so the legend goes, followed her mother  
at this seat of prophecy. Third in line,  
another Titan, Phoebe, child of Earth,  
was then assigned to occupy this throne.  
There was no force—Themis approved the change.  
Phoebe then gave it as a birthday gift  
to the god who takes his name from her, 10  
Phoebus Apollo. He left the island Delos,  
moving from his lake and ridge to Pallas, [10]  
to those shores where ships sail in to trade.  
Then he came to live on Mount Parnassus.  
A reverential escort came with him—  
children of the fire god, Hephaestus,  
highway builders who tame the wilderness  
and civilize the land. As he marched here,  
people came out in droves to worship him,  
including their king and helmsman, Delphus. 20  
Then Zeus inspired in him prophetic skills,  
and set him on this throne as fourth in line.  
Here Apollo speaks for Zeus, his father.  
My prayers begin with preludes to these gods. [20]  
My words also give special prominence  
to the goddess who stands outside the shrine,  
Pallas Athena. I revere those nymphs  
inhabiting Corycia's rocky caves,  
where flocks of birds delight to congregate,

where holy spirits roam. I don't forget 30  
 how Dionysus, ruler of this land,  
 divine commander of those Bacchic women,  
 ripped Pentheus apart, as if he were  
 a cornered rabbit. I also call upon  
 the streams of Pleistus and Poseidon's power,  
 and Zeus most high, who fulfills all things.  
 I'll take my seat now on the prophet's throne.  
 May I be fortunate, above the rest, [30]  
 to see far more than previous attempts.  
 If any Greeks are in attendance here, 40  
 let them draw lots and enter, each in turn,  
 as is our custom. I will prophesy,  
 following directions from the god.

*[The Priestess enters the temple, only to return immediately, very agitated. She collapses onto her hands and knees.]*

It's horrible!  
 Too horrible to say . . . awful to see.  
 It drives me back . . . out of Apollo's shrine.  
 My strength is gone . . . I can't stand up.  
 I have to crawl on hands and knees—my legs  
 just buckle under me . . . An old woman  
 overcome with fear is nothing, a child.  
 No more . . .

*[The Priestess gathers herself together and stands with great difficulty, holding onto the temple doors for support.]*

As I was entering the inner shrine— 50  
 the part covered up with wreaths—I saw him, [40]  
 right on the central navel stone, a man  
 the gods despise, sitting there, in the seat  
 reserved for suppliants, hands dripping blood.  
 He'd drawn his sword, but held an olive branch.  
 It had a tuft of wool on top, a mark  
 of reverence—it was large and white.  
 I saw all that distinctly. But then I saw  
 in front of him something astonishing,  
 on the benches groups of women sleeping— 60  
 well, they weren't exactly women,  
 I'd say more like Gorgons—then again,  
 not much like Gorgons either. Years ago,

I once saw a picture of some monsters  
 snatching a feast away from Phineas. [50]  
 But the ones inside here have no wings—  
 I checked. They're black and totally repulsive,  
 with loud rasping snorts that terrify me.  
 Disgusting pus comes oozing from their eyes.  
 As for their clothing—quite inappropriate 70  
 to wear before the statues of the gods,  
 or even in men's homes. I've never seen  
 a tribe which could produce this company,  
 a country which would admit with pride  
 that it had raised them without paying a price,  
 without regretting all the pain they cost.  
 Where does this end? That is Apollo's work. [60]  
 Let that be his concern. His force is strong—  
 what he reveals has healing power.  
 He reads the omens and can purify 80  
 the home, his own and other men's.

*[The scene changes to reveal the inside of the temple, with Orestes clutching the central stone (the navel stone) and the Furies asleep in front of him. Apollo enters from the back of the temple (the inner shrine). Apollo moves to stand near Orestes.]*

#### APOLLO

I'll not leave you—no, I'll stand beside you,  
 your protector till the end. Close at hand  
 or far away, I'll show no gentleness  
 towards your enemies. Right now you see  
 these frenzied creatures overcome with sleep,  
 just lying there, these loathsome maidens,  
 ancient children, hags. No god or man [70]  
 or animal has intercourse with them.  
 They're born for evil. That's why they live 90  
 within the blackest gloom of Tartarus,  
 under the earth. Olympian gods and men  
 despise them. But you should still keep going.  
 Do not give up. They'll chase you everywhere,  
 as you move along well-traveled ground,  
 across wide continents, beyond the seas,  
 through cities with the ocean all around.  
 Don't grow weary brooding on your pain.  
 And then, once you reach Athena's city,  
 sit down, and wrap your arms around her, 100 [80]  
 embrace her image. With people there

to judge your cause and with the force of speech,  
 the spell-binding power in words, we'll find  
 a way to free you from misfortune.  
 For I was the one who urged you on  
 to kill your mother.

ORESTES

My lord Apollo,  
 you have no knowledge how to be unjust.  
 That being the case, now learn compassion, too.  
 Your power to do good is strong enough.

APOLLO

Remember this—don't let fear defeat you  
 by conquering your spirit. And you, Hermes,  
 my own blood brother from a common father,  
 protect this man. Live up to that name of yours,  
 and be his guide. Since he's my suppliant,  
 lead him as if you were his shepherd—  
 remember Zeus respects an outcast's rights—  
 with you to show the way, he'll get better,  
 and quickly come among men once again.

110

[90]

*[Exit Orestes. Apollo moves back into the inner sanctuary. Enter the Ghost of Clytaemnestra.]*

GHOST OF CLYTAEMNESTRA *[addressing the sleeping chorus]*

Ah, you may be fast asleep, but now  
 what use is sleeping? On account of you,  
 I alone among the dead lack honour.  
 The ghosts of those I killed revile me—  
 they never stop. I wander in disgrace.  
 They charge me with the most horrific crimes.  
 But I, too, suffered cruelty from those  
 most dear to me. And yet, although I died  
 at the hands of one who killed his mother,  
 no spirit is enraged on my behalf.  
 Look here—you see these slashes on my heart?  
 How did they get there? While it's asleep  
 the mind can see, but in the light of day  
 we have no vision of men's destiny.  
 You've licked up many of my offerings,  
 soothing milk and honey without wine.  
 I've given many sacrificial gifts

120

[100]

130

with fire in my hearth at solemn banquets,  
 in that night hour no god will ever share.  
 I see all that being trampled underfoot. [110]  
 He's gone, eluded you—just like a fawn,  
 he's jumped the centre of your nets with ease. 140  
 He mocks your efforts as he moves away.  
 Listen to me. I'm speaking of my soul.  
 So rouse yourselves! Wake up, you goddesses  
 from underground. While you dream on I call—  
 now Clytaemnestra summons you!

*[The members of the Chorus begin to make strange sounds and to mutter in their sleep.]*

You may well moan—the man's escaped. He's gone. [120]  
 He's flown a long way off. The friends he has  
 are stronger than my own. You sleep on there  
 so heavily, no sense of my distress.  
 Orestes, the man who killed his mother, 150  
 has run off! You mutter, but keep sleeping.  
 On your feet! Why won't you get up? What work  
 has fate assigned you if not causing pain?  
 Sleep and hard work, two apt confederates,  
 have made these fearsome dragons impotent,  
 draining all their rage.

CHORUS MEMBER *[muttering in her sleep]*

Seize him!  
 Seize him! Seize him! Seize that man! Look out! [130]

GHOST OF CLYTAEMNESTRA

You hunt your prey, but only in your dreams,  
 whimpering like hounds who never lose  
 their keenness for the hunt. But you don't act! 160  
 Get up! Don't let exhaustion beat you down.  
 Sleep makes you soft—you overlook my pain.  
 Let my reproaches justly prick your hearts,  
 a spur for those who act with righteousness.  
 Blow your blood-filled breath all over him.  
 Let those fires in your bodies shrivel him.  
 Go on! Drive him to a fresh pursuit. Go!

*[The Furies begin to wake up slowly, one after the other. As they start to get up, the Ghost of Clytaemnestra exits.]*

EUMENIDES

CHORUS LEADER *[waking up and rousing the other Furies]*

Wake up! Come on, I'll wake you up. [140]  
Now do the same for her. Still sleeping?  
Stand up. Wipe that sleep out of your eyes. 170  
Let's chant our prelude—that should take effect.

*[The Furies, now awake, gather as a group, moving around trying to find Orestes or smell his track. They speak these lines as individual members of the larger group.]*

-Ah ha, what this? Dear sisters, something's wrong.

-I've been through a lot, and all for nothing.

-We're being made to suffer something bad,  
alas, an evil we cannot endure.

-Our quarry's slipped our nets. He's gone!  
Once sleep came over us, we lost our prey.

-You're disgraceful, Hermes, a child of Zeus  
who loves to steal.

-For a god you're young— [150]  
but still you trample on more ancient spirits. 180

-You showed that suppliant respect,  
a godless man, so vicious to his parent.

-You may be a god, but you're a thief.  
You filched a man who killed his mother.

-Who can say there's justice in such theft?

-In my dreams shame struck—  
it came on like a charioteer  
who gripped his cruel whip so tight,  
then hit under my heart,  
deep in my gut. 190

-I feel the executioner's scourge, [160]  
the one who wields a heavy lash,  
weighed down with pain.

-Younger gods are doing this—  
they push their ruling power  
beyond what's theirs by right.

Their throne drips blood  
around its foot,  
around its head.

-I see Earth's central navel stone  
defiled with blood, corrupted,  
stained with guilt.

200

-The prophet soils the hearth,  
pollutes the shrine himself,  
acting on his own behalf.  
Against divine tradition,  
he honours human things.

[170]

-He sets aside decrees of fate  
established long ago.

-Though he inflicts his pain on me,  
he'll never free that man.  
Let him flee underground,  
he'll find no liberty below.

210

-As he seeks to cleanse himself  
he'll meet the next avenger—  
a family member coming for his head.

*[Enter Apollo from the inner part of the shrine.]*

APOLLO

Get out! I'm ordering you to leave this house.  
Move on! Out of my prophet's sanctuary!  
Go now, or else you'll feel my arrows bite,  
glittering winged snakes shot from a golden string.  
Then, your agonies will make you choke,  
spit out black froth you suck from men,  
and vomit up the clotted blood you've drunk  
from murder. This shrine's no place for you.  
No, you belong where heads are sliced away,  
eyes gouged out—where justice equals slaughter—  
where youthful men are ruined by castration,

[180]

220



where others suffer mutilation, stoning,  
 where men impaled on spikes below the spine  
 scream all the time. That's the feast you love.  
 You hear me? And that's why gods detest you.  
 The way you look, your shape, says what you are—  
 some blood-soaked lion's den might be your home.  
 You must not infect those near this temple  
 with your pollution. So leave this place,  
 you flock without a shepherd, you herd  
 the gods despise.

230 [190]

CHORUS LEADER

Lord Apollo,  
 listen to what we say. It's our turn to speak.  
 You're no mere accomplice in this crime—  
 you did it all yourself. You bear the guilt.

240 [200]

APOLLO

What does that mean? Go on. Keep talking.

CHORUS LEADER

You told that stranger to kill his mother.

APOLLO

To avenge his father is what I said.  
 What's wrong with that?

CHORUS LEADER

Then you supported him.  
 You helped a man who'd just committed murder.

APOLLO

And I instructed him to come back here  
 to expiate his crime.

CHORUS LEADER

Then why insult us,  
 the ones who chased him here?

APOLLO

It's not right  
 for you to come inside my shrine.

CHORUS LEADER

We've been assigned to do this.

APOLLO

Assigned?

250

What's that? Proclaim your fine authority.

CHORUS LEADER

We chase out of their homes those criminals  
who slaughter their own mothers.

[210]

APOLLO

What about a wife who kills her husband?

CHORUS LEADER

That's not blood murder in the family.

APOLLO

What?

What about Zeus and his queen Hera—  
your actions bring disgrace on them.  
You ignore the strongest bonds between them.  
Your claim dishonours Aphrodite, too,  
goddess of love, from whom all men derive  
their greatest joys. With man and woman  
a marriage sealed by fate is stronger  
than any oath, and justice guards it.  
Now, if one partner kills the other one,  
and you're not interested in punishment,  
if you feel no urge to act, then I say  
the way you chase Orestes is unjust.  
I don't see why in one case you're so harsh  
when you don't really care about the other.  
However, goddess Athena will take charge—  
she'll organize a trial.

260

[220]

270

CHORUS LEADER

But that fugitive—  
he'll never be free of me, never.

APOLLO

Then go after him. Bring yourself more trouble.

CHORUS LEADER

Don't try to curb my powers with your words.

APOLLO

Your powers? Those I wouldn't take,  
not even as a gift.

CHORUS LEADER

Of course not.

You're already great, by all accounts—  
right by Zeus's throne. But for my part,  
since I'm called onward by a mother's blood,  
I'll chase this man with justice of my own.  
I scent the trail!

[230]

280

APOLLO

I'll help my suppliant  
and bring him safely home. With gods and men  
the anger of a man who seeks redemption  
will be dreadful, if, of my own free will,  
I abandon him.

*[Apollo exits into the inner shrine. The scene now changes to Athens, just outside the Temple of Athena. Orestes enters and moves up to the large statue of Athena.]*

ORESTES

Queen Athena,

I've come here on Apollo's orders.  
I beg your kindness. Please let me enter,  
a man accursed, an outcast. I don't seek  
ritual purification—my hands are clean—  
but my avenging zeal has lost its edge,  
worn down, blunted by other people's homes,  
by all well-beaten pathways known to men.  
I've stayed true to what Apollo told me  
at his oracle. Crossing land and sea,  
I've reached this statue by your shrine at last.  
Here I take up my position, goddess.  
I await the outcome of my trial.

290

[240]

*[Enter the Furies, like hunting dogs, still tracking Orestes by his scent. They do not see him at first.]*

## CHORUS LEADER

Ah ha! Here we have that man's clear scent,  
 a silent witness, but firm evidence.  
 After him! Like hounds chasing a wounded fawn, 300  
 we track him by the drops of blood he sheds.  
 Man-killing work—the effort wearies me.  
 My lungs are bursting. We've roamed everywhere,  
 exploring all the regions of the earth,  
 crossing seas in wingless flight, moving on [250]  
 faster than any ship, always in pursuit.  
 Now he's cornered here, cowering somewhere.  
 I smell human blood—I could laugh for joy!  
 Start looking for him! Seek him out again!  
 Check everywhere. Don't let him escape. 310  
 That man killed his mother—he must pay!

*[The Chorus of Furies catch sight of Orestes and crowd around him.]*

CHORUS *[different individuals]*

—He's over there! Claiming sanctuary,  
 at that statue of the eternal goddess,  
 embracing it. He must want a trial,  
 a judgment on his murderous violence. [260]

—Impossible! A mother's blood, once shed,  
 soaks in the earth and can't come back again—  
 the flowing stream moves through the ground,  
 then disappears forever.

—No. You must pay me back.  
 I'll suck your blood. 320  
 Drinking your living bones sustains me—  
 I feed upon your pain.

—Though it wears me out, I'll drag you down,  
 still living, to the world below. And there  
 you'll pay for murdering your mother.

—You'll see there other human criminals  
 who've failed to honour gods and strangers, [270]  
 who've abused the parents they should love.  
 They all receive the justice they deserve.

—Hades, mighty god of all the dead, 330  
 judges mortal men below the ground.  
 His perceptive mind records all things.

## ORESTES

My misery has been my teacher—  
 I know that men are cleansed in many ways,  
 that sometimes it's appropriate to speak,  
 sometimes to stay silent. And in this case  
 a wise master has ordered me to speak.  
 Blood on my hands is dormant now, fading— [280]  
 polluting stains from my mother's murder  
 have been washed away. When they were fresh, 340  
 Apollo in his temple cleansed my guilt—  
 slaughtering pigs to make me pure again.  
 It's a long story to describe for you,  
 right from the start, all the men I've seen,  
 ones I've stayed with, then left unharmed.  
 Time destroys all things which age with time.  
 Now, with full reverence and holy speech,  
 I invoke Athena, this country's queen.  
 I beg her help. Let her appear unarmed.  
 She'll win true allies in me, my land, 350 [290]  
 the Argive people. We'll trust her forever.  
 No matter where she is—in Libya,  
 in some region by the springs of Triton,  
 her birthplace, with her covered feet at rest,  
 or on the move, assisting those she loves,  
 or whether, like some bold commander  
 in the Phelegraeon plain, battle site  
 of gods and giants, she surveys the field—  
 I pray she'll come, for she's a goddess  
 and hears me, even though she's far away. 360  
 May she come here. May she deliver me.

## CHORUS LEADER

But Apollo's power will not save you—  
 nor will Athena's. You're slated to die [300]  
 abandoned and alone, without a sense  
 of heartfelt joy, a bloodless criminal  
 sucked dry by demons, just a shade—no more.

*[Orestes makes no answer.]*

What? You ignore my words and won't reply,  
 you, a victim fattened up for me,  
 my consecrated gift? You'll not perish  
 on any altar—no, I'll eat you alive.

370

*[Orestes continues to remain silent.]*

All right then, hear our song, a spell to chain you.

## CHORUS

Come, let's link our arms and dance—  
 Furies determined to display  
 our fearful art, to demonstrate  
 collective power we possess  
 to guide all mortals' lives.

[310]

We claim we represent true justice.  
 Our anger never works against  
 a man whose hands are clean—  
 all his life he stays unharmed.  
 But those men guilty of some crime,  
 as this one is, who hide away,  
 concealing blood-stained hands—  
 we harass them as testament  
 to those they've murdered.  
 Blood avengers, always in pursuit,  
 we chase them to the end.

380

[320]

Hear me, Mother Night,  
 mother who gave birth to me  
 so I could avenge  
 the living and the dead.  
 Leto's child, Apollo,  
 dishonours me—he tears  
 that man out of my hands,  
 the hare who cowers there,  
 who by rights must expiate  
 his mother's blood.

390

Let this frenzied song of ours  
 fall upon our victim's head,  
 our sacrifice—our frenzy  
 driving him to madness—  
 obliterate his mind.

400

[330]

This is our Furies' chant  
 It chains up the soul,  
 destroys its harmony,  
 and withers mortal men.

Remorseless Fate gave us this work  
 to carry on forever, a destiny  
 spun out for us alone,  
 to attach ourselves to those 410  
 who, overcome with passion,  
 slaughter blood relatives.  
 We chase after them until the end,  
 until they go beneath the ground.  
 In death they find small freedom. [340]

Let this frenzied song of ours  
 fall upon our victim's head,  
 our sacrifice—our frenzy  
 driving him to madness—  
 obliterate his mind. 420  
 This is our Furies' chant.  
 It chains up the soul,  
 destroys its harmony,  
 and withers mortal men.

These rights are ours from birth—  
 even the immortal gods [350]  
 may not lay hands on us.  
 We share no feasts with them,  
 no fellowship—their pure white robes  
 are no part of our destiny. 430

The task I take upon myself is mine,  
 to overthrow whole families,  
 when strife inside the home  
 kills someone near and dear.  
 We chase that murderer down,  
 the one who's spilled fresh blood.  
 For all his strength, we wear him down.

That's why we're now here,  
 eager to contest the charge,  
 to challenge other gods, 440 [360]  
 to make sure none of them

ends up controlling what is ours.  
 There will be no trial—  
 for Zeus despises us,  
 considers us unworthy,  
 refusing to converse with us  
 because we deal in blood.

The task I take upon myself is mine,  
 to overthrow whole families,  
 when strife inside the home  
 kills someone near and dear. 450  
 We chase that murderer down,  
 the one who's spilled fresh blood.  
 For all his strength, we wear him down.

Those proud opinions people have,  
 who raise themselves so high,  
 who puff themselves to heaven,  
 will melt away, dissolving  
 in dishonour underground,  
 when we, in our black robes, 460  
 beat out our vengeful dance— [370]  
 when we launch our attack.

Leaping from the heights,  
 we pound them with our feet—  
 our force trips up the runner  
 as he sprints for home,  
 a fate he cannot bear.  
 His mind is so confused  
 he does not sense his fall.  
 Dark clouds of his defilement 470  
 hover all around the man.  
 Murky shadows fall,  
 enveloping his home—  
 and Rumour spreads  
 a tale of sorrow. [380]

Leaping from the heights,  
 we pound them with our feet—  
 our force trips up the runner  
 as he sprints for home,  
 a fate he cannot bear. 480



So things remain.  
 We have our skills—  
 our powers we fulfill,  
 keeping human evil in our minds.  
 Our awesome powers  
 cannot be appeased by men.  
 Dishonoured and despised,  
 we see our work gets done.  
 Split off from gods,  
 with no light from the sun, 490  
 we make the path more arduous  
 for those who still can see  
 and for the blind.

What man is not in awe  
 or stands there unafraid [390]  
 to hear me state my rights,  
 those powers allowed by Fate  
 and ratified by all the gods,  
 mine to hold forever?

Those old prerogatives 500  
 I still retain—they're mine.  
 I have my honour, too,  
 though my appointed place  
 is underneath the ground  
 in sunless darkness.

*[Enter Athena.]*

ATHENA

I heard someone summon me from far away.  
 I was in Troy, by the Scamander's banks,  
 taking ownership of new property,  
 a gift from ruling leaders of Achaea,  
 a major part of what their spears had won, 510 [400]  
 assigned to me entirely and forever,  
 a splendid gift for Theseus's sons.  
 I've come from there at my untiring pace,  
 not flying on wings, but on this whirling cape,  
 a chariot yoked to horses in their prime.  
 Here I see an unfamiliar crowd,  
 strangers to this place, nothing I fear,  
 but astonishing to see. Who are you?

I'm talking to all those assembled here—  
 the stranger crouching there beside my statue, 520  
 and those of you like no one ever born, [410]  
 creatures no god has seen in goddesses,  
 in form a thing unknown to mortal men.  
 But to say such things about one's neighbour  
 who's done no wrong is far from just  
 and contravenes our customs.

CHORUS LEADER

Daughter of Zeus,  
 you'll find out everything—and briefly, too.  
 We are immortal children of the Night.  
 Below ground, where we have our homes,  
 we're called the Curses.

ATHENA

Now I know your race 530  
 I know what people call you.

CHORUS LEADER

But our powers—  
 these you'll quickly ascertain as well.

ATHENA

Those I'd like to learn. Please state them clearly. [420]

CHORUS LEADER

We hound out of their homes all those who kill.

ATHENA

Once the killer flees, where does he finally go?

CHORUS LEADER

Where no one thinks of joy, for there is none.

ATHENA

Your screams would drive this man to such a flight?

CHORUS LEADER

Yes—he thought it right to kill his mother.

ATHENA

Why? Was he forced to do it? Did he fear  
another person's anger?

CHORUS LEADER

Where's the urge  
so strong to force a man to kill his mother?

540

ATHENA

There are two sides to this dispute. I've heard  
only one half the argument.

CHORUS LEADER

What about the oath?  
He won't deny he did it or accept  
the guilt we charge him with.

ATHENA

Where do you stand?  
You wish to be considered righteous,  
but not to act with justice.

[430]

CHORUS LEADER

How? Teach me.  
You clearly have a mind for subtleties.

ATHENA

I assert that no one should use oaths  
to let injustice triumph.

CHORUS LEADER

Question him.  
Then make a righteous judgment.

550

ATHENA

Are you prepared  
that I should be the one to do this,  
to produce a final verdict?

CHORUS LEADER

Why not?  
We respect your worth, as you do ours.

## ATHENA

Stranger, do you have anything to say  
 by way of a response? State your country,  
 lineage, and circumstance. And then,  
 defend yourself against their accusations,  
 if you really trust the justice of your case,  
 as you sit here clinging to my statue, 560  
 a sacred suppliant beside my hearth, [440]  
 doing what Ixion did so long ago.<sup>1</sup>  
 Speak to me. Address all this directly.

## ORESTES

Queen Athena, your last words express  
 important doubts which I must first remove.  
 I'm not a suppliant in need of cleansing.  
 Nor have I fallen at your statue's feet  
 with my hands defiled. On these two points  
 I'll offer weighty proof. Our laws assert  
 a criminal polluted with blood guilt 570  
 will be denied all speech until he's cleansed  
 by someone authorized to purify  
 a man for murder, who sprinkles him  
 with suckling victim's blood. Some time ago, [450]  
 in homes of other men, I underwent  
 such purification rites with slaughtered beasts,  
 at flowing streams, as well. So, as I say,  
 there are no grounds for your misgivings here.  
 As for my family, you'll know that soon enough—  
 I'm an Argive, son of Agamemnon. 580  
 You may well ask his story—he's the man  
 who put that naval force together.  
 You worked with him to see that Ilion,  
 Troy's city, ceased to be. When he came home,  
 he died in a disgraceful way, butchered  
 by my mother, whose black heart snagged him [460]  
 in devious hunting nets—these still exist,  
 attesting to that slaughter in his bath.  
 I was in exile at the time. I came back.  
 I killed my mother—that I don't deny— 590  
 to avenge the murder of my father,

---

<sup>1</sup>Ixion murdered his father-in-law and became an outcast as a result. But Zeus forgave him and brought him to Olympus. There Ixion had sexual designs on Zeus's wife, Hera. Zeus punished him by attaching him to a wheel of fire and placing him eternally in Hades.

whom I truly loved. For this murder  
 Apollo bears responsibility,  
 along with me. He urged me to it,  
 pointing out the cruel reprisals I would face  
 if I failed to act against the murderers.  
 Was what I did a righteous act or not?  
 That you must decide. I'll be satisfied,  
 no matter how you render judgment.

## ATHENA

This is a serious matter, too complex  
 for any mortal man to think of judging. 600 [470]  
 It's not right even for me to adjudicate  
 such cases, where murder done in passion  
 merits passionate swift punishment.  
 Above all, you come here a suppliant  
 who's gone through all cleansing rituals,  
 who's pure and hence no danger to my shrine.  
 You thus have my respect, for in my view,  
 where my city is concerned, you're innocent.  
 But these Furies also have their function. 610  
 That's something we just cannot set aside.  
 So if they fail to triumph in this case,  
 they'll spread their poisonous resentment—  
 it will seep underground, infecting us,  
 bring perpetual disease upon our land,  
 something we can't bear. So stands the case. [480]  
 Two options, each of them disastrous.  
 Allow one to remain, expel the other?  
 No, I see no way of resolving this.  
 But since the judgment now devolves on me, 620  
 I'll appoint human judges of this murder,  
 a tribunal bound by oath—I'll set it up  
 to last forever. So you two parties,  
 summon your witnesses, set out your proofs,  
 with sworn evidence to back your stories.  
 Once I've picked the finest men in Athens,  
 I'll return. They'll rule fairly in this case,  
 bound by a sworn oath to act with justice.

*[Exit Athena.]*

## CHORUS

If his legal action triumphs, [490]

if now this matricide prevails,  
 then newly set divine decrees  
 will overthrow all order.  
 Mortals will at once believe  
 that everything's permitted.  
 From now on parents can expect  
 repeated blows of suffering  
 inflicted by their children—  
 now and in time yet to come.

630

For Furies who keep watch on men  
 will bring no anger down  
 on human crimes—so then  
 we loose death everywhere,  
 all forms of killing known to man.  
 So one, seeing his neighbour's pain,  
 will ask another, "Where's this end?  
 When does our suffering diminish?"  
 But the poor wretch can offer nothing—  
 his remedies are vain, without effect.

640 [500]

So when a terrible disaster strikes  
 let no one make the old appeal,  
 "Justice, you Furies—hear me,  
 you powers on your thrones!"  
 It may well happen soon—  
 a father in despair, a mother  
 in some new catastrophe,  
 may scream out for pity,  
 now the house of justice falls.

650 [510]

Sometimes what's terrible can work  
 to bring about what's good.  
 Such terror needs to sit on guard,  
 to check the passionate heart.  
 There is a benefit for men  
 to learn control through suffering.  
 For where is there a man or city—  
 both alike in this regard—  
 who still respects what's just  
 without a heart attuned to fear?

660

[520]

It's not right that men revere  
 a life without controls

or one enslaved by tyrants. 670  
 Those who practise moderation  
 in everything they do  
 acquire strength from god, [530]  
 though he hands down  
 his other gifts in other ways.

Our words stress self-control,  
 for arrogance, we know,  
 is surely born from sacrilege.  
 From a healthy heart and mind  
 comes the happiness men love, 680  
 the joy they ask for in their prayers.

To sum up everything about this case,  
 I'll tell you this—Justice has an altar.  
 Give that full human reverence.  
 Don't trample it profanely underfoot [540]  
 because self-interest sees advantages.  
 Remember punishment will come—  
 that outcome's fixed and permanent.  
 So each of you, above all else,  
 should honour parents, 690  
 pay them the deference you owe,  
 respect all guests and strangers  
 you welcome in your home.

For happiness will never fail [550]  
 the man who follows justice,  
 freely and without constraint.  
 He'll never be destroyed.  
 But the reckless man who goes too far,  
 who piles up riches for himself  
 in any way he can and disregards 700  
 all justice—I tell you this—  
 in time he'll have to strike his sail,  
 as storming torments break his ship  
 and his yardarm shatters.

He screams for help.  
 But no one listens.  
 In the middle of the seas  
 he fights—but all in vain.  
 Whirlpools suck him down,

while heaven roars with laughter  
 at the sight of this hot-tempered man  
 who used to boast with pride  
 he'd never come to grief  
 now helpless, panic stricken,  
 unable to ride out the waves.  
 He always lived for wealth—  
 now that, too, smashes on the reef,  
 the rock of Justice—he drowns,  
 unseen and unlamented.

710 [560]

*[The scene shifts to the Areopagus, the high court of Athens. Athena enters with a herald and ten citizens, the jury she has selected. A crowd of citizens enters with her. Orestes moves to the place where the accused stands.]*

ATHENA

Herald, blow the call for order in this court.  
 Raise that Etruscan trumpet, fill your lungs,  
 let these people hear an ear-piercing blast.  
 As they crowd into this court of judgment  
 it's better to have silence. The whole city  
 can listen to my laws, which are eternal.  
 So can these litigants. Then all will see  
 the justice in our verdict for themselves.

720

[570]

*[Enter Apollo. He moves to stand behind Orestes.]*

Lord Apollo, you have your own domain.  
 What's your role here? Announce that to us.

APOLLO

I've come here as a witness. That man,  
 the accused, according to our customs,  
 came a suppliant to my shrine, my hearth.  
 I purified him of the blood he spilled.  
 As his advocate, I share the blame  
 arising from his mother's murder.  
 Start the trial. You understand procedure.  
 Confirm that with a just decision.

730

[580]

ATHENA *[addressing the Furies]*

Then I'll begin the trial. You speak up first.  
 The plaintiff opens our proceedings.



Tell us the facts. Begin at the beginning—  
inform us clearly of the issues here.

740

CHORUS LEADER

There are many of us, but we'll keep  
our speeches brief.

*[Turning to interrogate Orestes.]*

Answer our questions,  
as we put them one by one. First, tell us—  
did you kill your mother?

ORESTES

Yes, I killed her.  
I don't deny the fact.

CHORUS LEADER

We take first fall.  
Three falls wins the match.

ORESTES

You gloat,  
but your opponent isn't pinned down yet.

[590]

CHORUS LEADER

Now you must describe the murder for us.  
How did you kill her?

ORESTES

I'll tell you—  
I drew my sword and slit her throat.

750

CHORUS LEADER

Who persuaded you to do this? Whose advice?

ORESTES

The orders of this god. He is my witness.

CHORUS LEADER

The prophet ordered you to kill your mother?

ORESTES

He did. And to this moment I have no regrets.

CHORUS LEADER

But if the verdict lays its hands on you,  
you'll change your story soon enough.

ORESTES

I'm confident. My father from his grave  
will send the help I need.

CHORUS LEADER

So you trust the dead,  
and yet you killed your mother?

760

ORESTES

I do, for she was guilty of two crimes.

[600]

CHORUS LEADER

How so? Inform the judges on this point.

ORESTES

She killed her husband and my father.

CHORUS LEADER

But her death evens out the score for her.  
You're still living.

ORESTES

When she was still alive  
you didn't hound her into exile. Why?

CHORUS LEADER

She and her victim shared no common blood.

ORESTES

And my mother and me? Are we blood linked?

CHORUS LEADER

How else could she sustain you in her womb,  
you murderer? Do you now reject  
the closest bond there is, a mother's blood?

770

ORESTES *[turning to Apollo]*

You must give evidence, Apollo.  
Take the lead for me. Did I kill her justly?

[610]

For I don't deny I did the murder.  
 But whether that act of shedding blood  
 was just or not, as you perceive the facts,  
 you must decide, so I can tell the court.

## APOLLO

Let me address this high court of Athena.  
 Tribunal members, what I have to say  
 will proceed from justice. I'm a prophet. 780  
 I cannot tell a lie. And never yet,  
 when I've been seated in my oracle,  
 have I said anything in prophecy  
 concerning woman, man, or city state,  
 that Olympian father Zeus did not command.  
 Make sure you understand how powerful  
 his justice is. That's why I urge you now— [620]  
 obey the will of Zeus, our father.  
 No oath has greater strength than Zeus.

## CHORUS LEADER

Then, Zeus, according to your reasoning, 790  
 told your oracle to give the order—  
 Orestes must avenge his father's death,  
 ignoring any rights his mother had.

## APOLLO

Yes. For these two things are not the same—  
 he died a noble man, a special king  
 who bears a sceptre given by the gods,  
 an honoured king who dies by murder,  
 and at a woman's hand, not in a fight  
 where arrows fly in from a distance,  
 as with the Amazons, but in a way 800  
 which we'll describe for you, Athena,  
 and those here ready to decide this case  
 when you cast your votes. He'd just come home, [630]  
 returning from a long and harsh campaign,  
 where in the eyes of loyal citizens  
 he'd won success beyond all expectation.  
 She welcomed him. Then, he took his bath.  
 As he stepped out—still on the outer rim—  
 she threw the cloak, his shroud, around him,  
 just like a tent. She caught him in those robes, 810  
 whose endless folds enclosed him like a net.

Then she hacked him down. I'm telling you,  
that's how the splendid leader of the ships  
went to his death. As for that woman,  
I speak of her to rouse a sense of shame  
in those men chosen here to judge this case.

## CHORUS

So your claim is Zeus thinks a father's death [640]  
is more significant? But on his own  
he chained up his old father, Cronos.  
Does that not contradict what you've just said? 820  
I ask you judges to take note of this.

## APOLLO

You monsters—how all the gods detest you!  
Zeus has power to smash those chains apart.  
For that he has a remedy, many ways  
to set us free. But once a mortal's blood  
has drained into the dust, the man is dead.  
And then there's no return. My father Zeus  
has made no charms for that, though he can change [650]  
all other things without a pause for breath.

## CHORUS LEADER

You plead to set him free. But think of this— 830  
will this man, who shed his mother's blood,  
who spilled it on the ground, return back home,  
to live in Argos in his father's house?  
Where are the public altars he can use,  
the family cleansing rites he can attend?

## APOLLO

I'll speak to that, as well. Make sure you note  
how right my answer is. That word mother—  
we give it to the one who bears the child.  
However, she's no parent, just a nurse  
to that new life embedded in her. 840  
The parent is the one who plants the seed,  
the father. Like a stranger for a stranger, [660]  
she preserves the growing life, unless  
god injures it. And I can offer proof  
for what I say—a man can have a child  
without a mother. Here's our witness,  
here—Athena, child of Olympian Zeus.

*[Apollo points to Athena.]*

No dark womb nursed her—no goddess bears  
 a child with ancestry like hers.<sup>2</sup> Athena,  
 since I know so many other things, 850  
 I'll make your city and your people great.  
 That's why I sent this man a suppliant  
 to your own shrine, so he might prove himself,  
 then place eternal trust in you, dear goddess, [670]  
 and you could win a new ally in him,  
 in his descendants, too, and thus create  
 an everlasting bond with his posterity.

ATHENA

Has each side said enough? Shall I now  
 instruct the judges to cast their votes,  
 acting on their judgment of what's just? 860

CHORUS LEADER

Though we've already shot our final arrow,  
 we'll stay to hear this contest to the end.

ATHENA

Why not? Now, as for you defendants,  
 what can I do to avoid your censure?

APOLLO

You have heard what you have heard.

*[To jurors.]*

My friends,  
 as you cast your ballots, make sure your hearts [680]  
 respect that oath you made.

ATHENA

You citizens of Athens, you judges  
 at the first trial ever held for murder,  
 hear what I decree. Now and forever 870  
 this court of judges will be set up here  
 to serve Aegeus's people. This place,  
 this Mount of Ares, is where Amazons,

---

<sup>2</sup>According to an old tradition, Athena had no mother. She sprang fully grown out of Zeus's head .

once marched in force, enraged at Theseus.  
 Here they pitched their tents. Then they built  
 a new city on the heights, with lofty walls  
 to match his own, making a sacrifice  
 to Ares, god of war, from whom this rock  
 derives its name, the Mount of Ares. [690]  
 From this hill Reverence and Terror, 880  
 two kindred rulers of my citizens,  
 will guarantee they don't commit injustice,  
 by day or night, unless the citizens  
 pollute the laws with evil innovations.  
 Once limpid waters are stained with mud,  
 you'll never find a drink. My people,  
 avoid both anarchy and tyranny.  
 I urge you to uphold this principle.  
 Show it due reverence. As for terror,  
 don't banish it completely from the city. 890  
 What mortal man is truly righteous  
 without being afraid? Those who sense the fear [700]  
 revere what's right. With citizens like these  
 your country and your city will be safe,  
 stronger than anything possessed by men  
 in Pelops' country or in Scythia.  
 So here I now establish this tribunal,  
 incorruptible and magnificent,  
 swift in punishment—it stands above you,  
 your country's guardian as you lie asleep. 900  
 I've gone through this at length to urge you on,  
 my citizens, today and in the future.  
 But now you must get up, cast your ballots,  
 decide this case, while honouring your oath. [710]  
 I'm finished—that's all I have to say.

*[The members of the tribunal begin to step forward and cast their votes into the urns.]*

#### CHORUS LEADER

Watch out. Don't ever show us disrespect.  
 For our united power can crush your land.

#### APOLLO

Let me remind you—fear the oracles,  
 not just mine, but those of Zeus the Father.  
 Don't make them barren.

CHORUS LEADER *[to Apollo]*

You interfere 910

in blood work that's not your proper business.  
Your oracles remain no longer pure.

APOLLO

When the first man-killer Ixion  
went a suppliant to Zeus for cleansing,  
was Zeus wrong to treat him as he did?

CHORUS LEADER

Argue all you want. But in this judgment  
if I don't prevail, I'll be back again [720]  
to bring this country to its knees.

APOLLO

Among all gods, old and new alike,  
you have no honour. I will triumph here. 920

CHORUS LEADER

Just as you triumphed in the house of Pheres,  
persuading Fate to free all men from death.<sup>3</sup>

APOLLO

Surely it's right to help a worshipper,  
especially when his need is desperate?

CHORUS LEADER

You made those ancient goddesses, the Fates,  
drunk on wine, then got them to suspend  
the oldest rule of order we possess.

APOLLO

Well, you'll soon lose this case. Then you can spew  
your poison and not hurt your enemies. [730]

CHORUS

You're young. You'd ride roughshod over me 930  
because I'm old. I'll await the verdict,  
see where this trial ends. I have my doubts  
about my anger at this city.

---

<sup>3</sup>The Furies cite this case as a time when Apollo interfered with the inevitability of death by allowing Admetus to purchase freedom from his own fate by substituting someone else.

ATHENA

It's now my task to give my final verdict.  
 And I award my ballot to Orestes.  
 No mother gave me birth—that's why  
 in everything but marriage I support  
 the man with all my heart, a true child  
 of my father Zeus. Thus, that woman's death  
 I won't consider more significant.  
 She killed her husband, guardian of their home.  
 If the votes are equal, Orestes wins.  
 Now, members of the jury, do your job.  
 Shake the ballots from the urns—and quickly.

940

[740]

*[The urns are emptied and the ballots counted.]*

ORESTES

O Phoebus Apollo, how did they vote?

CHORUS

O black mother Night, are you watching this?

ORESTES

Now for the result. Either I hang  
 or live on to see the light of day.

CHORUS

Either we're finished or our honour thrives.

APOLLO

Shake out all ballots, friends. Count them fairly.  
 Divide them with due care. Make no mistakes.  
 Errors in judgment now can mean disaster.  
 A single ballot cast can save this house.

950

[750]

*[The ballots are shown to Athena.]*

ATHENA

The numbers of the votes are equal—thus,  
 this man's acquitted of the murder charge.

ORESTES

O Pallas Athena, you've saved my house.  
 I'd lost my homeland—now you give it back,  
 and anyone in Greece can say, "This man



is once again an Argive, occupying  
 his father's property, thanks to Pallas, 960  
 thanks to Apollo, and thanks to Zeus,  
 third god and all-fulfilling saviour." [760]  
 Faced with these pleaders for my mother's cause,  
 Zeus chose to honour my father's death.  
 Now I'll go home. But first I make this oath  
 to your land and people for all time to come—  
 never will an Argive leader march in here  
 with spears arrayed against you. If he does,  
 in violation of this oath of mine,  
 from the grave we'll see his effort fails. 970  
 We'll bring him bad luck, trouble on the march, [770]  
 send birds of evil omen over him.  
 He'll regret the pains his campaign brings him.  
 But all those who keep this oath, who honour  
 for all time Athena's city, allies  
 who fight on its behalf, such citizens  
 we'll treat with greater favour and good will.  
 And so farewell to you, Athena,  
 farewell to those who guard your city.  
 In struggles with your enemies, I hope 980  
 you catch them in a stranglehold, win out,  
 and gain the spear denoting victory.

*[Apollo and Orestes leave. The Furies move to surround Athena.]*

#### CHORUS

You younger gods, you've wrenched our ancient laws  
 out of my grasp, then stamped them underfoot.  
 You heap on us dishonourable contempt. [780]  
 Now my anger turns against this land  
 I'll spread my poisons—how it's going to pay,  
 when I release this venom in my heart  
 to ease my grief. I'll saturate this ground.  
 It won't survive. From it disease will grow, 990  
 infecting leaves and children—that's justice.  
 Sterility will spread across the land,  
 contaminate the soil, destroy mankind.  
 What can I do now but scream out in pain?  
 The citizens make fun of us, the Furies. [790]  
 How can we put up with such indignity,  
 daughters of Night disgracefully abused,  
 dishonoured, shamed, our powers cast aside?

## ATHENA

Let me persuade you not to spurn this trial.  
 You've not been beaten—the votes were fair, 1000  
 the numbers equal, no disgrace to you.  
 But we received clear evidence from Zeus.  
 The one who spoke the oracle declared  
 Orestes should not suffer for his act.  
 So don't be vengeful, breathing anger [800]  
 on this land and drenching it with showers,  
 whose drops, like spears, will kill the seeds,  
 and blast its fruitfulness. I promise you  
 in all righteousness you'll have your place,  
 a subterranean cavern, yours by right. 1010  
 Beside the hearth you'll sit on glittering thrones,  
 worshipped with reverence by my citizens.

## CHORUS

You younger gods, you've wrenched our ancient laws  
 out of my grasp, then stamped them underfoot.  
 You heap on us dishonourable contempt. [810]  
 Now my anger turns against this land  
 I'll spread my poisons—how it's going to pay,  
 when I release this venom in my heart  
 to ease my grief. I'll saturate this ground.  
 It won't survive. From it disease will grow, 1020  
 infecting leaves and children—that's justice.  
 Sterility will spread across the land,  
 contaminate the soil, destroy mankind.  
 What can I do now but scream out in pain?  
 The citizens make fun of us, the Furies.  
 How can we put up with such indignity, [820]  
 daughters of Night disgracefully abused,  
 shamed, dishonoured, our powers cast aside?

## ATHENA

But you've not lost honour—you're goddesses.  
 Don't let your anger lead you to excess, 1030  
 to blast this land of men past remedy.  
 I have faith in Zeus. Why must I mention that?  
 Well, I'm the only god who knows the keys  
 to Zeus's arsenal where he keeps sealed  
 his lightning bolt. But there's no need for that.  
 Accept my argument. Don't let rash tongues [830]  
 hurl threats against this land, condemning it

to sterile fruitlessness. Ease your anger.  
 Let your fury's black and bitter waves recede.  
 You can live with me, receive full honours. 1040  
 The first fruits of this fertile land are yours,  
 forever, all those offerings for heirs,  
 for marriages—from now on they're yours.  
 With all this, you'll praise what I'm advising.

## CHORUS

Such suffering for me.  
 My ancient wisdom  
 driven underground,  
 despised, dishonoured.  
 The shame, my shame.  
 This pure rage I breathe 1050 [840]  
 consumes me utterly.  
 What sinks under my ribs  
 and pains my heart?

O Night, my mother,  
 the cunning of those gods,  
 too hard to overcome,  
 takes all my ancient powers,  
 and leaves me nothing.

## ATHENA

I'll bear with your rage, for you are older,  
 and thus your wisdom far exceeds my own. 1060  
 But Zeus gave me a fine intelligence as well. [850]  
 So let me tell you this—if you leave here,  
 for this land you'll feel a lover's yearning.  
 As time goes on, my citizens will win  
 increasing honour, and you, on your thrones,  
 seated outside the house of Erechtheus,  
 a place of honour, will win more respect  
 from lines of men and women filing past  
 than you could find in all the world beyond.<sup>4</sup>  
 So cast no stones for bloodshed on this land, 1070  
 my realm. Do not corrupt our youthful hearts,  
 intoxicating them with rage, like wine, [860]  
 or rip the heart out of a fighting cock

<sup>4</sup>Erechtheus was a legendary king of Athens.

to set it in my people, giving them  
 a thirst for reckless internecine war.  
 Let them fight wars abroad, without restraint  
 in those men driven by a lust for fame.  
 I want no birds who fight their wars at home.  
 That's what I offer you. It's yours to take.  
 Do good things, receive good things in honour. 1080  
 Take your place in a land the gods all love.

## CHORUS

Such suffering for me— [870]  
 my ancient wisdom  
 driven underground,  
 despised, dishonoured.  
 The shame, my shame.  
 This pure rage I breathe  
 consumes me utterly.  
 What sinks under my ribs  
 and pains my heart? 1090  
 O Night, my mother,  
 the cunning of those gods,  
 too hard to overcome,  
 takes all my ancient powers,  
 and leaves me nothing. [880]

## ATHENA

I'll not tire of telling you your gifts,  
 so you can never lodge complaints that I,  
 a newer god, or men who guard this land  
 failed to revere such ancient goddesses  
 and cast you out in exile from our city. 1100  
 No. But if you respect Persuasion,  
 holding in reverence that sacred power  
 whose soothing spell sits on my tongue,  
 then you should stay. If that's not your wish,  
 it would be unjust to vent your anger  
 on this city, injuring its people,  
 enraged at them from spite. It's up to you—  
 take your allotted portion of this land, [890]  
 justly entitled to your share of honour.

## CHORUS LEADER

Queen Athena, this place you say is ours, 1110  
 what exactly is it?

ATHENA

One free of pain,  
without anxieties. Why not accept?

CHORUS LEADER

If I do, what honours would I get?

ATHENA

Without you no house can thrive.

CHORUS LEADER

You'd do this? You'd grant me that much power?

ATHENA

I will. Together we'll enrich the lives  
of all who worship us.

CHORUS LEADER

This promise you make—  
you'll hold to it forever?

ATHENA

Yes I will.  
I don't say anything I don't fulfill.

CHORUS LEADER

Your magic's doing its work, it seems—  
I feel my rage diminish.

1120 [900]

ATHENA

Then stay.  
In this land you'll win more friends.

CHORUS LEADER

Let me speak out a blessing on the land.  
Tell me what I might say.

ATHENA

Speak nothing  
of brutal victories—only blessings  
stemming from the earth, the ocean depths,  
the heavens. Let gusting winds caress the land  
in glorious sunlight, our herds and harvests  
overflow with plenty, so they never fail

our citizens in time to come, whose seed  
 will last forever. Let their prosperity  
 match how well they worship you. I love  
 these righteous men, the way a gardener loves  
 his growing plants, this race now free of grief.  
 These things are yours to give. For my part,  
 I'll see this city wins triumphal fame  
 in deadly wars where men seek glory,  
 so all men celebrate victorious Athens.

1130

[910]

## CHORUS

Then we'll accept this home  
 and live here with Athena.  
 We'll never harm a place  
 which she and Ares  
 and all-powerful Zeus  
 hold as a fortress of the gods,  
 this glorious altar, the shield  
 for all the gods of Greece.  
 I make this prayer for Athens,  
 prophesying fine things for her—  
 bounteous happy harvests  
 bursting from the earth,  
 beneath a radiant sun.

1140

[920]

1150

## ATHENA

To all my citizens I'll act with kindness,  
 setting in place these goddesses among them—  
 powerful divinities, implacable—  
 whose office is to guide all mortals' lives  
 in everything they do. If there's a man  
 who's never felt their weight, he's ignorant  
 of where life's blows arise. His father's crimes  
 drag him before these goddesses, and there,  
 for all his boasting, his destruction comes—  
 dread silent anger crushing him to dust.

[930]

1160

## CHORUS

Hear me speak my blessing—  
 let no winds destroy the trees  
 nor scorching desert heat move in  
 to shrivel budding plants,  
 no festering blight kill off the fruit.  
 May Pan foster fertility

[940]

and make the flocks increase,  
 to every ewe twin lambs,  
 all born in season, and in Athens  
 may the earth be rich in treasure,  
 paying fine gifts to Hermes,  
 god of unexpected luck.

## ATHENA

Do you hear that, you guardians of my city?  
 The blessings they will bring? They're powerful,  
 the sacred Furies, among immortal gods,  
 among the dead below. With mortal men  
 it's clear they work their wills decisively,  
 for some a life of song, for others lives of tears.

## CHORUS

I forbid those deadly accidents  
 which cut men down before their time.  
 And all you gods with rightful powers,  
 let our lovely girls all live  
 to find a husband. Hear our prayers,  
 you sacred Fates, our sisters,  
 you children of the Night,  
 who apportion all things justly,  
 who have a place in every home,  
 whose righteous visitations  
 at all times carry weight, everywhere  
 most honoured of the gods.

## ATHENA

I rejoice to hear these love-filled blessings  
 conferred upon this land. It pleases me  
 Persuasion kept watch on my tongue and lips,  
 when I met their fierce refusal. But Zeus,  
 the patron god of our assemblies,  
 has triumphed. Our struggle here for justice  
 has left us victorious forever.

## CHORUS

I pray man-killing civil strife  
 may never roar aloud  
 within the city—may its dust  
 not drink our citizen's dark blood,  
 nor passions for revenge incite

those wars which kill the state.  
 Let men give joy for joy,  
 united by their common love,  
 united in their enmities—  
 for that cures all human ills.

## ATHENA

You see now how these Furies seek their way  
 with well intentioned words? I can predict  
 these terrifying faces will provide  
 my citizens all sorts of benefits.  
 So treat them kindly, just as they are kind.  
 Worship them forever. Then you'll keep  
 your land and city on the path of justice,  
 in everything you do attaining glory.

1210

[990]

## CHORUS

Rejoice, rejoice  
 amid the riches you deserve  
 rejoice, you citizens,  
 who dwell with Zeus, 1220  
 who love that virgin girl,  
 Athena—and she loves you.  
 You manifest your wisdom  
 at the proper time, nestling  
 underneath Athena's wings,  
 while Zeus looks on in awe.

[1000]

*[Enter a group of citizens to lead Athena's procession, some bearing unlit torches, some robes, and some leading animals for sacrifice.]*

## ATHENA

And you too rejoice. I must lead the way,  
 show you to your rooms, by sacred torchlight  
 carried by your escort. Now you can go—  
 move with speed under the earth, and there  
 with sacred sacrificial blood hold down  
 what would destroy my land and send above  
 what brings prosperity, so that our city  
 may prove victorious. And now you citizens,  
 you children of Cranaus, king of this rock,  
 lead our new residents for life away.  
 May all citizens look on with favour  
 at those who bring such favours to them.

1230

[1010]



CHORUS

Farewell, once more farewell,  
 all those who live in Athens, 1240  
 gods and men, inhabitants  
 of Pallas' city. Pay us respect,  
 while we live here among you—  
 you'll have cause to celebrate  
 the fortunes of your lives. [1020]

ATHENA

My thanks to you for these words of blessing.  
 Now I'll send you down by blazing torchlight  
 to your homes beneath the earth, with this escort  
 of those duty-bound to guard my statue.  
 That seems right. For the most precious part 1250  
 of all the land of Theseus will come out,  
 a splendid throng of girls and mothers,  
 groups of older women.

*[From the processional company some women bearing scarlet robes move forward to place the robes on the Furies. Athena speaks directly to them.]*

Invest these Furies  
 with their special crimson robes. Honour them.  
 Then, move on with the torches, so this group, [1030]  
 our fellow residents, can show the love  
 they bear this land, and for all time to come  
 bring our city strength and great good fortune.

*[The women dress the Furies in the scarlet robes and sing the final song of joy and thanks, as the entire procession of Athena, Furies, and citizens moves off stage.]*

THE WOMEN OF ATHENS

Move on with your loyal escort,  
 you mighty children of the Night, 1260  
 children without children, no longer young,  
 yet glorious in your honours.  
 You citizens, nothing but blessings in your songs.

Deep in those primeval caverns  
 far underground, our sacrifices,  
 the sacred honours we bestow on you  
 will maintain our city's reverence.  
 All of you, nothing but blessings in your songs.

EUMENIDES

Come forward, sacred goddesses,  
benevolent and gracious to our land,  
come forward with the flaming torches,  
rejoicing as we move along our way.  
Now raise triumphal cries to crown our song!

[1040]

1270

Peace now reigns forevermore  
between Athena's people and their guests.  
For all-seeing Zeus and Fate herself  
have worked together for this ending.  
Now raise triumphal cries to crown our song!

*[The entire group moves off singing and dancing.]*